Bobirjon Bakhtiyorov

Things NOT to do when applying for Top Universities!

1. ***<u>Don't Exaggerate or fabricate your activities!</u>***
    a. Admissions officers go through thousands of applications each cycle, and they've developed a sixth sense for spotting exaggerated or fabricated activities. Faking/Exaggerating your achievements can severely damage your credibility and harm your chances of admission because the Admissions officer will not believe you anymore.
        i. For example, let's say you participated in an internship during your sophomore year of high school. In reality, you might have dedicated 5-6 hours a week to this internship. However, for the sake of enhancing your college application, you claim that you committed 20 hours a week on top of your full-time school schedule and several other extracurricular activities. An admissions officer can easily spot this discrepancy. They understand the demands of a full-time high school schedule, especially when coupled with after-school activities. Claiming a 20-hour-a-week internship in addition to all of that raises red flags because it's simply not feasible for most students to manage. Therefore, it's very important to present your extracurricular involvement accurately and avoid exaggeration. Instead, focus on the quality of your experiences and what you learned from them, rather than trying to impress with inflated time commitments.
2. ***<u>Don't treat the Recommendation Letters lightly!</u>***
    a. Choose your Teachers wisely for your Recommendation Letters!
        i. The recommendation letter shows the Admissions officer how you are in a classroom enviornemnt. They look for traits that would be a good addition to their University. Stanford Ex-Admissions officers say that Admissions officers work for the Professors of the University. Hence, they are choosing students that Professors will want!
        ii. Therefore, it's crucial to choose your recommenders wisely. Opt for teachers who know you well and can provide a detailed, personalized account of your abilities and growth over time, rather than those who may hold a prestigious title but have little insight into who you truly are. If you are very close with the teacher I even recommend you to take a look at your letter before Submission as this is something I did!
            1. When selecting a recommender, think about those who have seen you grow, whether in academic settings, extracurricular activities, or even challenges you've overcome. Their insights can paint a

vivid picture of who you are beyond grades and test scores. Avoid asking teachers solely based on their status or your grade in their class; instead, choose those who genuinely understand your journey and can authentically advocate for your potential to succeed at a top university.

iii. Lastly, remember your application is a big puzzle. So make sure the characteristics given by your professor matches with the overall theme of your character.

3. ***Don't write a generic Personal Statement Essay!***

a. Your personal statement is the most important piece of writing!!!!
   i. This is your opportunity to show that you are more than numbers. This essay puts a face to all the "numbers" you have in your application. This is where you convey your unique story, personality, and aspirations to the admissions committee. Writing a generic essay that could apply to anyone is a missed opportunity and can make your application blend in with thousands of others. Admissions officers are "bored speed readers" who read countless essays every cycle, so a generic, cookie-cutter approach won't make a lasting impression.
   ii. For example, imagine an essay that starts with a cliché like, "I've always wanted to help people," followed by a broad, impersonal recounting of various volunteer experiences. While the sentiment is positive, this approach is overused and will make admissions officer roll their eyes before they move on to the next application. Admissions officers are looking for essays that delve deeper into your personal experiences and reflect your unique voice. They want to understand what drives you, what challenges you've overcome, and how these experiences have shaped your perspective and goals.

b. The lesson is: START YOUR ESSAYS NOW!!!! It took me 28 drafts to get a "perfect" essay. The more you write and the more comments you get the better your essays will get. So, do not leave it till the last second!

4. ***I will provide more materials like this!***